

IDENTIFICATION WITH SELF

Greetings, my dearest friends. Blessings for every one of you. Blessed be this hour! May all of you again derive benefit from these words even though it so often happens that the real understanding of these lectures comes but later, whenever in this pathwork you reach within yourself those levels that apply to the contents of a particular lecture. When you find your corresponding inner problems and conflicts, then the words of these lectures really make sense. Sometimes this happens only years after you have heard or read a lecture. But when it does happen, it is an entirely new understanding, a new experience. You then know what is meant by the difference between intellectual and emotional understanding.

For the new friends, it will not be easy to follow for the very reason just mentioned. For those who already pursue this path, it is not always possible to really understand. How much more difficult then is it for someone who is not involved with self-exploration. Even intellectual understanding is not possible if previous talks leading up to this one are not known. Still, you might feel a deep inner echo with some thought advanced here, and this might sooner or later help to bring you to this path of liberation. A seed may be sown that will come to fruition at a later period.

And now, my friends, I wish to discuss a topic I have not gone into before, and that is identification with oneself, as opposed to identification with others. Last time, I talked about man's relationship to time. You will recall that I said, in essence, that very rarely indeed does man live in the now. He pushes into the future. He pulls back into the past. Often the two contradictory movements happen simultaneously. In both alternatives, man strains away from the now.

Only when you live in the now, do you live in reality. You cannot live in reality when you strain into the future because such future, as you hope or imagine or fear it, may never come to pass in exactly that way. But let us suppose, theoretically, that it were possible to imagine the future exactly as it will be (which, of course, can never be the case). Even then, it would still be living in illusion because it does not happen at that moment. Therefore you do not react to and experience it in reality, but only in fantasy.

On the other hand, if you pull backward into the past and even if you try to relive it in exactly the way it was (if this were possible, which again, it is not), it would still be an illusion because at this moment you are in a new segment of time. You react in fantasy, live in fantasy, and not in the reality of the now. One of the characteristics of reality is its constant state of flux. It is contrary to being stagnant or static.

Needless to say, you cannot exactly duplicate the past any more than you can imagine a future and live it. Your own subjective colorings, coming from your desires and fears, distort the reality picture; make you blind as to factors that existed or will exist; make you ignore your own different

state of mind and feelings even though you deliberately try to deny this change -- and thus stunt growth -- in order to live your fantasy. You fear to allow the natural flux of time to become part of your soul, because of your distorted ideas and misconceptions. If you could trust the flux of time, the benign quality of the movement and growth of time, you could allow yourself to follow suit and thereby make it possible for your inner faculties to swing into harmony with this stream of time. You would then not need to manipulate time by holding it back or pushing it forward. You would not then need to fear the future, nor wish for fulfillment in the future, nor would you have to reach back in the past for a fulfillment in the past. This, after all, happens only because you do not trust the future; you do not trust yourself to live the now when the future comes. This distrust is often partly justified, due to your destructive and unrealistic concepts and attitudes which prevent fulfillment in the now whenever this now happens to be. But by either pulling back into the past or by pushing forward into the future, you seek the wrong remedy against these obstructions; you seek an "easy way out" rather than tackling that in you which prevents your living as fully as you are meant to.

In order to live in the now and in reality, you have to have a keen sense of reality of yourself. All too often this is not the case. Most people do not experience themselves in reality. This is mostly a subtle process. It can rarely be pinpointed or proven, except in very advanced states. Most of you are probably convinced that you have a sense of the reality of yourself. However, upon much closer examination of certain symptoms, which you learn to evaluate as such and follow through, you will eventually find that this is fallacious. And this is always the first step towards eliminating a destructive condition. All of my friends have gone through similar experiences before, regarding other factors of their inner lives. Outwardly and consciously, nothing seemed to indicate a certain negative condition. You were convinced all was well with you in this respect. And only after closer inspection did you find, deeply hidden, the very opposite to be true. You then understood how this hidden distortion destroyed so many possibilities for fully living, for happiness, and for meaningfulness. Finding what is, can never harm you. Not seeing what is, that does harm you!

You will eventually find this lack of reality of yourself. Before I talk about self-identification, I would like to indicate a few symptoms by which you may begin to detect this lack of feeling real. In the crassest possible way, this aspect can be found in the symptom that most people do not feel that, for themselves, death is a reality. To experience oneself as mortal is not negative or morbid, as might well be misunderstood. A realistic sense of one's own mortality is never a burden. It is never depressing or fear producing. It never diminishes the now nor the reality of living, regardless of what concepts or belief one holds regarding afterlife. It is quite the opposite. Mostly, it goes hand in hand that he who never experiences his mortality as a reality is the person who is morbidly afraid of death. In this vital question, you will find a distinct symptom to be your lack of experiencing yourself as real. For if you do not feel your mortality as real, you cannot possibly feel your aliveness as being real.

There are, of course, many other less crass or extreme symptoms which tell about your sense of reality of yourself or, putting it in different words, your lack of self-identification. Such symptoms, for instance, may be in the fleeting moment you may discover, here or there, that what you think, or what you feel, or what you will utter or have uttered in a conversation, how it appears is important rather than how it is. This is a distinction not easily determined because it is so subtle, but once you discover it, it stands out and is bound to show you the vital difference between

identification with self or with others, between experiencing yourself as real or not. Even the most vital and essential feelings, thoughts, and inner experiences are so often shifted in this way.

Or you may discover, in a fleeting, vague, and hazy way, that your attitude as to your actions, thoughts, and feelings is geared to the idea of "if only others could see me act, think, and feel that way." In this moment of discovery, you will detect that you shift your identity from yourself to others. Therefore your sense of reality of yourself is dependent on others. You live through others.

Now, please, my friends, I do not want to be misunderstood. I do not want you to believe that when I mention these symptoms, you are reprimanded, that you are invited to quickly change. This can be even less the case than with any other miscondition that we have ever been concerned with on this path. By trying forcefully and intentionally to eliminate this condition, you will only make the condition worse because you then identify with me instead of with yourself. You merely obey another authority. You have merely shifted your identification.

Rather than trying to immediately correct these observations, greet them as symptoms which will lead you, once you discover it, like a red thread, like a well-marked road, into deeper areas. This, then, will afford you deeper understanding and awareness about yourself, about this whole area we are concerned with at the moment.

And now we will approach the topic of identification in a more direct way. To a degree, your present-day psychology and psychiatry has of course found this aspect and is aware of its healthy and unhealthy manifestations. But I wish to go into it a little deeper and wish to shed light on it from a somewhat wider outlook.

When the infant is born and grows into a little child, its ego is still so weak that it cannot sustain itself. As we have discussed in different connections and contexts, the child is dependent on the more powerful, stronger adult world. Everyone realizes and understands this dependency for physical life. It is dependent for nourishment, for protection from danger, for shelter. But the subtle bodies have their own lives which function according to very similar laws as the physical ones. The child is not only dependent in regard to its physical existence, but also in regard to its emotional, intellectual, and spiritual existence. Love has to be given to the child, just as food. It cannot obtain either by the fruits of its own resources. The mature adult does not wait helplessly to be loved. Love comes to him by his own capacity for loving and relating. He never feels insecure and helpless because he has no love. Whenever you find such aspects in yourself, you now know that this indicates emotional immaturity. Love is an essential in life. But the weak ego of the child is in reality dependent. The mature adult is not more dependent on it than he need be dependent on others for his physical subsistence.

Similarly, the child is not capable of forming his own ideas and concepts. He cannot discriminate between reason, common sense, logic, and their opposites. He is dependent for being supplied with the ideas and principles which are guideposts to his growing up process. To deny the child any such guideposts would not cause him to quicker and better form his real independence. On the contrary, if you let a child starve, he does not become better equipped to cope with the struggle of existence. If you do not give a child love, he does not become better able to love. It is just the opposite. Only when the child grows, provided this growth occurs organically, will he gradually cut the ties to the parents by standing on his own feet financially; by developing his

capacity to love and thereby not being in dependent need that love be given to him; by discriminating the ideas and principles he has heard and learned and then discarding what he cannot accept, by changing, by searching, and then later perhaps returning to the same ideas, but only after finding them by himself and for himself. They are his. When this process occurs, organic growth prevails; independence of body, soul, and spirit is established. The dependency bond to the parental authority is cut. The healthy spirit will cut this triple bond even if the parents do not encourage such severance, but possessively try to hold it intact.

But the spirit, or soul, that is burdened with unresolved problems will not desire to cut it, but, quite on the contrary, will do its best to maintain it. Such maintenance is often done in precarious, hidden, and distorted ways. Unfortunately, there is so often the misunderstanding that emotional independence means isolation, whereas withdrawal from involvement while frantically holding onto dependency is interpreted to mean the ability to love. I have often mentioned this in the past, but now find it necessary to repeat it in the present context as a warning. If you ponder the above, you cannot fail to see that the truth is the very opposite. The mature person stands, outwardly and inwardly, on his own two feet, and in this very process lies the capacity for mutuality, exchange, involvement, giving and receiving -- in short, relationship.

In this very refusal (inner and unconscious) to cut the ties with protective authority, lies identification with such authority. The child needs a good example from which it molds its ego, that later affords the possibility to stand free. But if such a good example serves only to continue the identification and thereby prevent self-identification, the original good purpose has been misconstrued. In such a case, the child wants to become the parent with whom he favorably identifies, and later tries to be that parent rather than find and be himself.

It is important to understand that such identification may not at all be obvious or on the surface. And it is also necessary to understand that negative identification must also be looked for. In other words, a parent whom one hates or despises and certainly does not want to emulate can, on an unconscious level, also be identified with. In one's very fear not ever to be like this parent, and suspicion that one might be, is embedded identification, with perhaps a vague idea that this parent may be better off despite his unlovable traits. In short, this entire preoccupation (though often very unconscious) may be a negative identification. The tie to this undesirable parent that one rejects may even be more difficult to sever than the tie to a cherished parent. It is very important to understand this, my friends.

For the child, positive identification is desirable. For an adult, positive identification is often as undesirable as a negative one because both prevent the evolvment of the self.

I would warn you against trying to judge or evaluate in what way you may identify with whom, and doing so merely with your intellectual equipment. This may be very misleading. What actually exists in you may be entirely different. Only very extensive work in this respect will reveal the truth. You may consciously admire and wish to emulate one parent and despise and hate the other. Yet, in the course of this work, many of you have found that you have trends, attitudes, and behavior patterns similar to those of the hated and despised parent. This often came as a shock. But such finding indicates that you identify with the very parent you least wish to be identified with. So beware of quick judgment.

The original identification with the parent later is often substituted with others who take their place -- without the conscious self being aware of it. Such identification not only occurs with individuals, but also with groups, nationalities, religions, political affiliations. Even minority groups, rebelling against the masses, serve as a means with which to identify in this psychological distortion. Conformism is really a consequence of the need to identify with someone more powerful. Such conforming, or identifying with, can also occur under the guise of nonconformism and apparent individualism. But if such individualism is very strained, if too great a point is made of it, it indicates that the "conforming" group is conformed and identified with. So often, a rebellious minority group believes they are free in that sense; and according to all appearances, they seemingly defy conformism. But whenever this stringent need to prove something exists, one can be certain that one finds a flaw underneath. The truly independent, free individual does not have to make a show of it. He does not have to be militant about it. So a rebellious nonconforming minority group may very well serve as a substitute to identify oneself with.

People may also identify with causes. No matter how valid and good the cause itself may be, if it serves as a substitute for identifying with oneself, there is harm. The harm is not in your embracing this worthy cause, believing in it and working for it (all this can very well be done with inner freedom), but rather in your need of a substitute for yourself to lean on because you have not found within yourself that area that is still as weak as a child, because you have not understood the hidden motivation of your reason for embracing the cause.

I do not advocate a life in which you separate yourself from all ideas, groups, loyalties, and causes. This would be isolation and even irresponsibility towards society. But there is a great difference, my friends, between embracing a cause out of a healthy conviction and inner freedom, gaining your sustenance from your own inner resources; and in using the worthiest of causes to replace the well that exists within you, if only you would go and tap it.

The extreme form of such identification with others because of a weak ego that has not grown is conformism to public opinion and parroting the views of others. But the same condition exists with almost every human being in one form or another, only in a much subtler way and therefore more difficult to detect. That certainly does not mean that it is less important to find it and grow out of it.

Some time ago, I gave a lecture on self-alienation. Needless to say, there is a connection between that topic and the one we are discussing tonight. But it is not the same. Self-alienation is a product, or a result, of nonidentification with the self. In other words, when discussing self-alienation, we still discussed an effect, while we are now coming close to a cause. Whenever you find psychological conditions and currents in which you feel an emotional dependency on others, you can be sure that you are on the right track of finding, in some respect, that you have not established your selfhood. Whenever you feel that vague fear of others not supplying you with what you need and expect of them -- be it financial help, be it approval, love, acceptance -- whenever feelings of anxiety indicate that here you deal with more than the natural need for human interdependence (which never causes emotions of anxiety and often other negative emotions as well), it might very well be visualized by a need for receiving your inner lifeblood from sources outside yourself. That such a state of affairs is not natural and necessary hardly needs to be emphasized once you see it clearly. From there, it follows that it can be changed, that you do not have to live in such useless dependency that weakens rather than strengthens you.

Do not overlook rebellion against a need of being accepted or agreed with. You know from past experience that behind such rebellion you very often find a very stringent need for the very thing you rebel against.

When the emotional and spiritual umbilical cord has not been cut, the self cannot possibly grow. It can grow only to a very limited degree, as the baby in the mother's womb can grow only up to a certain point. In order to effect further growth, the baby has to evolve, the physical umbilical cord has to be cut. Only then, further physical growth is possible. The process is not any different regarding the inner personality. When the inner "umbilical cord" is not cut, you are, in the truest sense of the word, dependent on others for your right to exist. All the psychological aspects of appeasing, of betraying, of self-alienation, and so on and so forth, are just an indication that you have not yet been able, at least in certain areas, to identify with yourself. Therefore you have no sense of reality of yourself. Subsequently you cannot experience each living moment in fullness. Wherever and whenever such lack of selfhood, such dependency on others through identification exists, you are bound to find that, in one way or another, you try to use others. Since you condemn yourself to living a parasitic life, festering on others, you cannot help but try using those on whom you depend. In this hidden using can be found the distortion of your imagined "love." You pretend love when you merely need and have to use because without that you feel yourself sinking. You feel you have no reality other than that reality accorded to you. The more you use those whom you need, the weaker you become; and therefore the more do you believe that you need others to strengthen you.

Living in the now is living in the wave of time. In this dimension, time flows in a certain movement and rhythm. This movement can be determined by the seasons, by day and night, by the positions of the planets in relationship to the earth, and the position of the earth in relationship to the planets, all of them constantly moving in space. These movements create certain rhythmic waves. To a tiny degree, man, in the course of the centuries, has sensed some of these laws of the rhythmic movement of time, such as, for example, in astrology. Only very limited understanding has been gained here. But everyone knows and feels and often even expresses it in terms of having "good times" or "bad times." There will be a period when things go well; whatever one undertakes goes well, has good results. One feels freer than usual, with a hopeful outlook in spite of existing problematic conditions, and there is fulfillment, to a degree at least. And then there are the times of the downward curve of the wave when all seems to go wrong. Anyone who perseveres with a wholehearted desire to look at himself in truth will, sooner or later, come to a point when these so-called "bad times" -- which are literally the manifestations of the disharmony man has created in his relationship to his time dimension -- when such times will yield such victory, such understanding that he will then no longer experience the rhythmic downward curve in the time movement as a depressing or upsetting or disadvantageous period. For each living moment, fully experienced in the reality of the now, will then yield adventure, excitement in a peaceful harmonious way, worthwhile vital living. But this cannot happen unless you first learn to evaluate and understand the negative in you, and thus your "bad times." Then you will be in your time dimension. Then you will experience yourself in reality. And this peace, this inner anchor with yourself, is something that cannot be described. It cannot possibly be replaced with any other goal or seemingly worthwhile aims, desirable accomplishments, or states. There is a wealth, there are riches contained in each individual soul. They are yours for the asking. It is often sad for us to notice how man turns in the wrong direction to seek this fulfillment he vaguely senses as existing, how he literally wastes his time

seeking solutions and fulfillment in the wrong direction. For only when he has tapped the well of his inner wealth will he stop straining away from the now, and he will therefore not be estranged from himself. Thus he will not derive this sustenance from other sources. As long as he remains dependent on this foreign life source, he has to go through all sorts of means that diminish and weaken his real self even more.

What I mentioned before about using others is so important to understand, to find, and to see in yourself. Do not merely apply this to the extreme outer manifestation of using others; try to see it in its more subtle version that you have to use since your life really seems to depend on others. Therefore you need to be in control. So many of my friends have begun to see this strong tendency of needing to be in control. Different individuals resort to different means so as to exert control. This has to be found in each individual case, how it applies; what your particular means are; how you fear not to be in control; how you destroy relationships because there is a mutual battle for control, each one inwardly acting as though it were a fight for survival; how you distort issues in this unrealistic fight for survival; how you spoil all living substance toward the growth of mutuality and fulfillment! This need for control causes you to manipulate others, yourself, your vital natural feelings. By this very process, the self cannot evolve strong and free and independent.

Wherever you find your stringent need to be in control -- of others, of a situation, of a relationship -- you have a direct clue to your nonidentification with yourself. If you look at this trend from the point of view discussed here, if you use these little clues and highlights as points from which to pursue and go on, while understanding the harm of this inner stunting, you will certainly come to the nucleus of your deliberate self-denial causing so much unnecessary hardship. You will then be able to go about bringing yourself out. This will be easier than finding such negative conditions in the first place. But first you have to be in full awareness of your parasitic clinging to others, of identifying with others so as to depend on them in one way or another. You will see the ties that you have so far refused to cut and could therefore not establish their roots within yourself. Once you find these areas, it will be comparatively easy, although certainly no sudden or abrupt process, to cut the ties and become yourself and identify with yourself.

And now my friends, you have a few weeks to ponder over this lecture. Since you will now have an opportunity to ask all questions pertaining to specific lectures at the discussions, we will now deal with questions that have no bearing on this lecture. Prepare your own interpretations for the discussion so that we can then see if you have really understood. Prepare all facets that are unclear. Put your confusion into concise questions. This in itself is of great value. Any questions that do not pertain to the assigned lectures planned for discussion can be asked now.

QUESTION: Will you kindly explain the phenomenon of sleep?

ANSWER: Man's subtle bodies need to shed the burden of the physical body, of gross physical matter. He could not sustain a lifetime without this rest. Physical matter is a burden to the real personality. I mean that in the literal sense of the word. Man needs a respite from this burden, when he can move and be in freedom. This happens in a different dimension. In this other, wider, freer dimension, there is respite, relaxation, and a gathering of strength. This is essentially the main reason for sleep. It is the function of sleep. This freeing of the gross matter and thereby moving into a wider dimension does not only restore the physical organs, but actually the physical organs are

restored by a restoration of the psychic blood stream that is regenerated in a different dimension. The psychic or subtle bodies are always the cause; the physical body is the effect.

With great love, I now leave you, blessing each one of you. This blessing contains a great strength, a substance that can bring truth, and regeneration to your soul so as to find the necessary stamina and will to establish yourself in yourself. Be in peace. Be in God!

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